THE BULLOCK PRESIDENCY

BOOK TWO: MR. PRESIDENT

Chapter 11 — "Ratified"

Friday, November 8, 2024 – Tuesday, December 24, 2024

COLD OPEN — "THE LAST PHONE CALL"

INT. SUNRISE HILL — MARC'S STUDY — BEL AIR — AFTERNOON

SUPER: FRIDAY, NOVEMBER 8, 2024 — 1:47 PM PST / 4:47 PM EST

SUPER: THREE DAYS AFTER ELECTION DAY

A study lined with scripts, framed letters, and the DOT warning letter from 2023. Hanging beside it now, in a new frame: a text message, printed out. "Mr. Bullock. Roy Chapman, Tyler's father. Congratulations on Texas. I voted for you. Don't make it a whole thing. — R.C."

The President-elect, MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK (32), stands at the window in a gray sweater, phone to his ear. ESTHER BULLOCK (32) sits in the leather armchair, watching him. In the doorway, ELXA BULLOCK (34), arms crossed, and Secret Service Special Agent in Charge RUTH OKONJO (48).

We hear only Marc's side.

MARC
Mr. President.

(listens)
...Thank you, sir. I appreciate you calling. I know it's not an easy call to make.

(listens)
Yes, sir. Arizona and Nevada this morning.

(listens for a long time)
Sir, I want to say something. You ran hard. Harder than anybody I've ever seen. You got shot at, and you got up. Twice. I said it at the debate and I'll say it now: whatever we disagree about, I respect that. I always will.

(listens; a small, surprised laugh)
...Yes, sir. Bet. I'll take you up on that.

(listens)
Thank you, Mr. President. Take care of yourself.

He lowers the phone. Stands still for a long moment.

ESTHER
What did he say? At the end?

MARC
He said he'd come to dinner. If I invited him.

ELXA
You said you'd beat him fair and square and then invite him to dinner. In April. On Instagram.

MARC
He said he watched it.

A long silence.

MARC
He said, "You're a tough kid. Don't let them change you."

Esther crosses the room and puts her arms around him from behind. He leans back into her.

ASSOCIATED PRESS — FRI, NOV 8, 4:52 PM EST

Trump concedes to Bullock in phone call after Arizona and Nevada are called, final electoral margin 359–179

THE NEW YORK TIMES — SAT, NOV 9

Trump Concedes, Ending a Bitter Race; Bullock Calls Him 'Tough' and Accepts a Dinner Invitation

Twitter · @TheBullpenDaily

TRUMP CONCEDED. BY PHONE. MARC SAID HE'D TAKE HIM UP ON DINNER. "BEAT YOU FAIR AND SQUARE AND THEN INVITE YOU TO DINNER" WAS NOT A BIT. IT WAS A PROMISE.

501K Retweets · 3.4M Likes

ACT ONE — "FIVE STATES"

MONTAGE — NOVEMBER 9 TO DECEMBER 16, 2024

AP — SAT, NOV 9

Bullock wins Arizona and Nevada; final Electoral College count 359–179, largest margin since 1988

POLITICO — MON, NOV 11

Bullock names sister Elxa Bullock White House chief of staff in first major transition appointment

Critics question a family hire; allies point to her two-year record running the campaign's operations.

— WEDNESDAY, NOVEMBER 13, 11:02 AM EST. The Oval Office. PRESIDENT JOE BIDEN (81; he turns eighty-two a week from today, on November twentieth) welcomes the President-elect. They sit by the fireplace. Reporters are ushered in for ninety seconds. Biden pats Marc's knee and tells the press pool the young man has "more energy than the whole building." Marc says he's "just trying not to break anything." The pool laughs. Then they're ushered out, and the two men talk for two hours.

VARIETY — FRI, NOV 15

Grace Bullock Named White House Press Secretary; Says First Act Will Be "Refusing to Pay for Anything Else on Twitter"

THE WASHINGTON POST — WED, NOV 20

Bullock taps campaign counsel Arianna Cummings, a Harvard Law graduate and former TV actress, as attorney general

At 32, she would be the youngest attorney general since Robert F. Kennedy, who was 35.

AP — FRI, NOV 22

Mucarsel-Powell defeats Scott by 2,814 votes after Florida recount, giving Democrats 52 Senate seats

AP — TUE, NOV 26

Democrats clinch House majority; final count 238–197 as last California races are called

Twitter · @PattiGrove

> Final numbers. House 238–197. Senate 52–48. Electoral College 359–179. I'm framing this tweet.
>
> **211K Retweets · 1.6M Likes**

INT. SMILLEY HOUSE — DINING ROOM — CASCADE HEIGHTS, ATLANTA — DAY

SUPER: THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 28, 2024 — THANKSGIVING — 3:14 PM EST

The long mahogany table, extended with two card tables and a folding table from the church basement. Every leaf in the house. Forty people.

For the first time in fifty-five years, the Smilleys and the Donohues are at the same table.

At the head, of course: ODESSA SMILLEY (96). At her right: CORNELIUS (66). At her left, where Cornelius sat for forty years: an honored guest. JOAN DONOHUE (76).

Around the table: VICTOR DONOHUE (78), NATASHA (53) and ROBERT BULLOCK (55), LORRAINE SMILLEY (62; sixty-three in two weeks), NEIL (40), SIMONE (37), AUNT BEA SMILLEY-OWENS (69), GRACE (30), ELXA (34), AMOND (32), HARMONY (32), GLORIA BAKER (58), Marc and Esther, EMMA and VICTORIA (12), LYRIC (10), BET the dog under the table. At the far end, by special invitation: ROY (67) and MAE CHAPMAN (65), who flew in from Houston, and TYLER (32).

The President-elect of the United States sits at the folding table from the church basement, because Odessa said "family doesn't get special seats, baby, except me."

Odessa raises a hand. The room goes silent.

ODESSA
Before we eat. Grace.

She closes her eyes. Everyone bows their heads.

ODESSA
Lord. Thank you for this food. Thank you for these hands that made it. And thank you for bringing my families home.

(beat)
Fifty-five years ago, a girl from Spelman left this city, and a boy from this house never got over it. And then he was gone, and this family spent fifty years at war with hers.

Across the table, Joan's eyes are closed. Her hands are shaking.

ODESSA
And today she's sitting in the chair at my left hand. And her great-grandbabies are my great-grandbabies. And her grandson is going to be President of the United States. Lord, you are a funny God. You take your time. But you are funny.

Soft laughter around the table. Victor wipes his eyes.

ODESSA
Thaddeus. Baby. We're all here. Amen.

EVERYONE
Amen.

A beat. Then Joan, very quietly, reaches over and takes Odessa's hand. Odessa holds it. Neither woman says anything.

Then Victoria, from the folding table:

VICTORIA
Can we eat now? Daddy said there's mac and cheese from BOTH grandmas.

NATASHA
Mine's better.

ODESSA
Natasha Bullock. You are in my house.

NATASHA
...Yours is better, Mrs. Smilley.

ODESSA
That's right.

The table erupts in laughter.

Instagram · @esthersmilleybullock — NOV 28

[Photo: one enormous table, forty people, Smilleys and Donohues side by side. Odessa at the head. Joan at her left. The President-elect at a folding table at the far end.] Caption: Fifty-five years. One table. Big Mama put my husband at the kids' table. Nobody argued.

31.4M likes

POLITICO — TUE, DEC 3

The 28th Amendment's last mile: Kentucky, Missouri, Montana and two mystery states

— TUESDAY, DECEMBER 10, 4:18 PM EST. FRANKFORT, KENTUCKY. The Kentucky State Capitol. A special session called by the governor. The House chamber. The roll call, read by the clerk. A REVEREND ELLISON (70s), white-haired, Black, in a clerical collar, sits in the front row of the gallery beside Cornelius Smilley. When the final tally appears, 64–35 in the House after a Senate vote of 25–13 that morning, Ellison turns to Cornelius.

REV. ELLISON
That's 1998 paid in full, Cornelius.

CORNELIUS
With interest, Reverend.

SUPER: KENTUCKY RATIFIES — 34 OF 38

— THURSDAY, DECEMBER 12, 11:52 AM CST. JEFFERSON CITY, MISSOURI. The Missouri House. The Speaker, a Republican, gavels the vote closed: ratified. In the gallery, a dignified woman in a church hat, MOTHER DORIS WALKER (81), of St. Louis AME, the Speaker's mother-in-law, nods once at the Speaker. The Speaker nods back. Cornelius, beside her, doesn't smile. He texts Lorraine instead.

CORNELIUS — 12:58 PM EST

Missouri. 35. Happy birthday, Lorraine. I'm sorry I'm not home for it.

LORRAINE — 12:59 PM EST

Sixty-three years old and my husband just gave me a state. Best present you've ever bought me. Come home Saturday.

SUPER: MISSOURI RATIFIES — 35 OF 38

— FRIDAY, DECEMBER 13, 2:30 PM CST. LINCOLN, NEBRASKA. The only one-house, officially nonpartisan state legislature in America. Forty-nine senators, no party labels on their nameplates. A special session. Thirty-three yes, sixteen no. Twenty-five was all it needed. On a phone in the gallery, a text from Arianna to Cornelius: "How did you get Nebraska?" Cornelius, on the floor of the chamber shaking hands, replies: "I didn't. Roy Chapman's sister-in-law is married to a state senator from Grand Island."

SUPER: NEBRASKA RATIFIES — 36 OF 38

EXT. MONTANA STATE CAPITOL — HELENA — STEPS — DAY

SUPER: MONDAY, DECEMBER 16, 2024 — 3:41 PM MST / 5:41 PM EST

Snow on the copper dome. Eleven degrees. Arianna Cummings (32), Attorney General-designate, in a black parka over a suit, stands on the Capitol steps, shivering, watching her breath. Beside her, in a

fur-lined trapper hat, the MONTANA LEGISLATIVE COUNSEL, a lanky rancher-turned-lawyer named HANK DORSEY (61). At his feet: a large yellow Labrador. GUNNER.

Gunner is staring at Arianna. He has stared at her with the same suspicion on six previous visits to Helena since August.

HANK DORSEY
House vote's in twenty minutes. Senate passed it this morning, twenty-six to twenty-four. It's close in the House. Real close.

ARIANNA
How close?

HANK DORSEY
Couple of ranchers from the Hi-Line still on the fence. They think the whole thing's a Hollywood stunt.

ARIANNA
Mr. Dorsey, I've been to this building seven times since August. I've eaten at every diner on Last Chance Gulch. I learned to say "Hi-Line" correctly. Your dog still hates me.

Hank looks down at Gunner. Gunner looks at Arianna.

HANK DORSEY
He doesn't hate you. He just doesn't trust people from California.

ARIANNA
I'm from Chicago.

Gunner's ears go up. He tilts his head.

HANK DORSEY
...Huh. You never said that.

ARIANNA
You never asked. I grew up on the South Side. Went to Stanford for school. Stayed in L.A. for work. I'm a Chicago girl.

Gunner stands. Walks over. Sniffs her parka. Then, very deliberately, sits down on her boots and leans his entire hundred-pound weight against her legs.

Hank Dorsey stares at his dog.

HANK DORSEY
Well, I'll be damned. My wife's from Chicago. He's the only thing in Montana that likes her.

Arianna kneels down in the snow and puts her arms around Gunner. He licks her face.

Twenty minutes later, inside the Montana House chamber, the vote board lights up: 51–49. Ratified. Two ranchers from the Hi-Line voted yes. One of them, asked by a Helena reporter why he changed his mind, says only: "My granddaughter. And that lawyer was nice to the dog."

SUPER: MONTANA RATIFIES — 37 OF 38

Twitter · @ArianaCummingsEsq

Montana. 37. Gunner and I are friends now. One more.

301K Retweets · 2.4M Likes · 6:02 PM EST

Twitter · @ArianaCummingsEsq's replies

@MontanaLegislature: "Gunner has issued no formal statement but was seen leaning on the Attorney General-designate."

412K Likes

ACT TWO — "THE THIRTY-EIGHTH"

INT. GEORGIA STATE CAPITOL — HOUSE CHAMBER — ATLANTA — DAY

SUPER: TUESDAY, DECEMBER 17, 2024 — 11:58 AM EST

SUPER: THE ELECTORAL COLLEGE MEETS

The Georgia State Capitol, its dome covered in gold leaf mined from Dahlonega. The same building on whose steps, in the spring of 1969, a young man in a sharp suit laughed with his arm around a girl in a Spelman sweater.

Today, in the House chamber, Georgia's sixteen presidential electors gather at noon, as required by federal law, to cast their votes. Fifteen of them sit in a row at a long table. The sixteenth, at the end of the table, in a wheelchair, in a white church hat:

ODESSA GRANT SMILLEY. Ninety-six years old. Presidential elector for the State of Georgia, nominated by the state Democratic Party at the special request of her grandson, State Senator Neil Smilley.

In the gallery: Cornelius, Lorraine, Neil, Simone. And, having flown in that morning, Marc and Esther, with the twins.

The Secretary of State calls the roll. One by one, the electors sign their certificates.

GEORGIA SECRETARY OF STATE
Elector Odessa Grant Smilley.

Odessa takes the pen. Her hand shakes. Simone, in the gallery, whispers to Neil.

SIMONE
Her hand shook in 1946.

NEIL
That's how you know it matters.

Odessa signs. Slowly. Beautifully. In the flowing cursive she learned at a one-room school outside Albany in 1934.

ODESSA
(into the microphone, voice thin but clear)
For President of the United States: Marc-Anthony Bullock. For Vice President: Amond Baker.

(beat)
And for my husband, the Reverend Josiah Smilley, and my son, Thaddeus Smilley, who

never got to cast one.

The chamber, which is supposed to be silent and formal, breaks into applause. In the gallery, the President-elect stands. Then everyone stands.

SUPER: 12:14 PM EST — GEORGIA'S 16 ELECTORAL VOTES CAST FOR BULLOCK-BAKER

INT. NORTH CAROLINA STATE LEGISLATIVE BUILDING — HOUSE CHAMBER — RALEIGH — AFTERNOON

SUPER: TUESDAY, DECEMBER 17, 2024 — 1:52 PM EST

A modernist building of gold-tinted glass and pyramidal skylights. The North Carolina General Assembly, in session for veto overrides since early December. Today, a special order of business: House Joint Resolution 1101, ratifying the proposed 28th Amendment. The Senate passed it this morning, 30 to 20.

The House gallery is packed. Pastors. Dozens of them. In collars and church suits. AME, Baptist, COGIC, Methodist. Some Black, some white. Many from the eastern counties, the Black Belt: Halifax, Edgecombe, Northampton, Hertford, Bertie. The same counties that held the line for Joe Biden in March.

In the front row of the gallery: the PASTOR FROM RALEIGH from February and October, REV. HAROLD BRYANT (68). Next to him, his own small framed card tucked into his breast pocket where nobody can see it: Cornelius, who flew up from Atlanta on the 12:40 flight, straight from the Georgia Capitol.

On the floor below, the SPEAKER OF THE NORTH CAROLINA HOUSE (50s), a Republican, at the rostrum.

NC HOUSE SPEAKER
The question before the House is the adoption of House Joint Resolution 1101. The clerk will open the vote. Members will vote.

The electronic vote board on the wall. One hundred and twenty names. Green lights and red lights begin flickering on.

Rev. Bryant leans over to Cornelius.

REV. BRYANT
You need sixty-one.

CORNELIUS
I know what I need, Harold.

REV. BRYANT
In February, you sat in my church office and told me love wasn't a qualification.

CORNELIUS
And in October, I called you back and told you I was wrong.

REV. BRYANT
You did. Took you eight months. I want you to know I told my congregation about that call. Two Sundays in a row. I said, "If Cornelius Smilley can change his mind, any man in this state can."

Cornelius turns to look at him. Rev. Bryant nods down at the floor of the chamber.

REV. BRYANT
Representative Hollis. Halifax County. Republican. Third pew of my church for twenty years. His mama's eighty-nine.

On the vote board: "HOLLIS (R-HALIFAX): YES."

REV. BRYANT
Representative Tate. Edgecombe. Republican. His granddaughter wrote him a letter. I know because he showed it to me in the parking lot. It said, "Papa, a girl my age asked a question and the whole country answered. Please answer too."

"TATE (R-EDGECOMBE): YES."

The tally on the board climbs. 58. 59. 60.

Then it stops. Three names haven't voted yet.

Thirty seconds. A minute. The chamber goes absolutely silent. In the gallery, the pastors bow their heads.

Cornelius closes his eyes. His lips move. The prayer his father used to say over him.

On the board, one more name turns green.

"61."

NC HOUSE SPEAKER
(a beat, then evenly)
Have all members voted? ...The clerk will close the machine. Sixty-one having voted in the affirmative, fifty-nine in the negative, House Joint Resolution 1101 is adopted.

A beat. And then the gallery ERUPTS. Pastors on their feet, shouting "AMEN!" Arms raised. A woman in a purple church hat begins to sing "Lift Every Voice and Sing," and within seconds the entire gallery is singing it, and the Speaker doesn't even try to gavel them quiet.

SUPER: 2:14 PM EST — NORTH CAROLINA RATIFIES — 38 OF 38

SUPER: THE 28TH AMENDMENT IS RATIFIED.

Cornelius sits motionless while the gallery sings around him. He opens his eyes. Looks up at the skylights. At the gold-tinted December light pouring down.

CORNELIUS
(very quietly)
...Five, Thad. Five out of five.

Rev. Bryant puts an arm around his shoulders. Cornelius, for the second time this year, lets a man see him cry.

INT. ABC NEWS — SPECIAL REPORT — NEW YORK — AFTERNOON

SUPER: 2:19 PM EST

The urgent music. The "ABC NEWS SPECIAL REPORT" graphic. DAVID MUIR (51) at the anchor desk, called away from a lunch.

DAVID MUIR
Good afternoon. We're coming on the air with breaking news. Moments ago, the North Carolina House of Representatives voted sixty-one to fifty-nine to ratify the proposed Twenty-Eighth Amendment to the Constitution of the United States. North Carolina is the thirty-eighth state to ratify, three-fourths of the states. And that means that, as of this moment, the Twenty-Eighth Amendment is part of the Constitution.

CHYRON: ABC NEWS SPECIAL REPORT: 28TH AMENDMENT RATIFIED — NORTH CAROLINA BECOMES 38TH STATE

DAVID MUIR
The amendment lowers the minimum age to serve as President and Vice President from thirty-five to twenty-five. It is the first amendment to the Constitution since the Twenty-Seventh, which was ratified in May of 1992. Four months after Marc-Anthony Bullock was born.

(beat)
And it means that President-elect Bullock, thirty-two, and Vice President-elect Amond Baker, thirty-two, will be constitutionally eligible to take the oath of office on January twentieth. And it happened on the same day that presidential electors in all fifty states and the District of Columbia met to cast their votes, three hundred and fifty-nine of them for Bullock and Baker.

A beat. Muir looks down at his notes. Then directly into the camera.

DAVID MUIR
Two hundred and thirty-seven days ago, I sat at this desk and said that changing the age requirement would require two-thirds of both houses of Congress and thirty-eight states, and that it wasn't clear what Mr. Bullock meant when he said, quote, "we'll fix that too."

(beat)
Now we know.

INT. BULLOCK-BAKER TRANSITION HEADQUARTERS — WASHINGTON, D.C. — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 2:21 PM EST

A federal office building on 1800 G Street, provided by the General Services Administration to every presidential transition. Four floors of government-issue furniture, now covered with "BET." stickers. Three hundred transition staffers, all on their feet, watching the screens.

In the main conference room, with the video feed from Raleigh on one screen and ABC on another: Patti Grove (60), Grace (30), Tayia (32), Tyler (32), Dante Reyes (43). And on a laptop on the table, a FaceTime call from Helena, Montana: Arianna, still in her parka, a

yellow Labrador's head resting on her shoulder.

When "38 OF 38" appears on the screen, the room EXPLODES. Grace screams so loud the Secret Service agent at the door reaches for his earpiece. Tyler lifts Tayia off her feet. Patti Grove sits down very slowly in a government-issue chair and puts her face in her hands.

TYLER
THIRTY-EIGHT! THIRTY-EIGHT!

GRACE
I'M CALLING HIM. I'M CALLING MARC. WHERE IS HE?

DANTE
He's in a car between the Georgia Capitol and the Atlanta airport. With Agent Okonjo. And his wife. And his daughters. And a ninety-six-year-old presidential elector who refuses to let go of his hand.

On the FaceTime screen, Arianna is crying into Gunner's fur.

ARIANNA
(through the laptop)
It's done. It's in the Constitution. Patti, it's in the CONSTITUTION.

PATTI
(from behind her hands)
I know, baby. I know.

Patti lowers her hands. Her eyes are wet. For the first time in twenty months, Patti Grove looks her age.

PATTI
Four presidential campaigns. Thirty years. I have never once seen the Constitution change. Not once. I learned it in eighth grade and I thought it was a stone tablet.

(beat)
A nine-year-old asked a question. And the Constitution changed.

INT. SECRET SERVICE MOTORCADE — SUV — I-85, ATLANTA — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 2:22 PM EST

The back of an armored black SUV. Marc in the middle seat. Esther on one side. Odessa on the other, still in her church hat, still holding his hand from the Capitol. Emma and Victoria in the rear

seat. Agent Okonjo in front.

Marc's phone has buzzed four hundred times in two minutes. He hasn't looked at it. He's watching ABC on Esther's phone, held between them.

"THE 28TH AMENDMENT IS RATIFIED."

Nobody in the car says anything.

Then Victoria, from the back:

VICTORIA
Daddy. Does this mean you're allowed to be President now?

MARC
(his voice barely working)
Yeah, Vic. It means I'm allowed.

VICTORIA
Like, legally?

MARC
Like, the Constitution says I'm allowed.

EMMA
Article Two, Section One, Clause Five is superseded by the Twenty-Eighth Amendment, Section One. It's in my spreadsheet.

Marc laughs. Wipes his eyes. Odessa squeezes his hand.

ODESSA
Call Lyric.

MARC
What?

ODESSA
Before anybody else. Before the President. Before your mama. Call that baby. She asked. She gets to hear it first.

Marc looks at her. Then he scrolls past four hundred notifications and dials "LYRIC (HOUSE PHONE)."

INTERCUT — INT. BAKER HOUSE — VIEW PARK, LOS ANGELES — LYRIC'S BEDROOM — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 11:22 AM PST

Lyric's pink landline rings. It's a Tuesday. She's home from school early. Harmony told her to wait by the phone, and wouldn't say why.

LYRIC (10) picks it up.

LYRIC
Baker residence, Lyric speaking.

MARC (V.O.)
Lyric-bird. It's Uncle Marc.

LYRIC
Hi, Uncle Marc. Mommy said wait by the phone. Why do I have to wait by the phone?

MARC (V.O.)
Remember at your birthday party? Last year? You asked me a question.

LYRIC
I asked why you can't be the President.

MARC (V.O.)
And I said "Bet." But there was a problem. The Constitution, which is the big rulebook for the whole country, said I was too young.

LYRIC
I know. Auntie Arianna told me. It's Article Two.

MARC (V.O.)
Well. Thirty-eight states had to change the rulebook. And twenty minutes ago, North Carolina was number thirty-eight.

Lyric is very quiet.

LYRIC
...So the rulebook changed?

MARC (V.O.)
The rulebook changed, baby. Because of your question.

A long, long pause. Lyric sits down on her bed. Holds the pink phone with both hands.

LYRIC
Uncle Marc?

MARC (V.O.)
Yeah?

LYRIC
Can I ask another question?

MARC (V.O.)
(laughing, crying)
Oh, no. Oh no. What's the question, Lyric?

LYRIC
Can BET come to the White House?

In the SUV, the President-elect of the United States laughs so hard he has to put his head on Odessa's shoulder.

MARC (V.O.)
Yes. Yes, Lyric. BET can come to the White House.

LYRIC
Bet.

ACT THREE — "WHAT IT MEANS"

INT. ABC NEWS — SPECIAL COVERAGE — NEW YORK — EVENING

SUPER: TUESDAY, DECEMBER 17, 2024 — 6:30 PM EST

An expanded "World News Tonight." Muir at the desk. GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS (63), DR. MALCOLM REESE (55), REP. (RET.) DIANE KASTLE (61), and the ABC POLITICAL DIRECTOR.

DAVID MUIR
The Twenty-Eighth Amendment is now part of the Constitution. What does it mean? George.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
Three things. First, the immediate one. The constitutional crisis everyone was bracing for on January twentieth is over. There won't be an Acting President. There won't be a Speaker of the House sworn in as caretaker. On January twentieth, at noon, Marc-Anthony Bullock will take the oath as the forty-seventh President, and Amond Baker as the fiftieth Vice President.

DAVID MUIR
Second?

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
Second, the precedent. Before today, the Constitution had been amended only twenty-seven times in two hundred and thirty-five years, and not once in thirty-two years. The idea that it could be changed, quickly, in a single year, with bipartisan support, by the will of the people, was almost theoretical. Now it isn't. That cuts both ways. It means the Constitution is alive. It also means that future movements, on the left or the right, will look at this year and say, "We can do it too."

REP. (RET.) DIANE KASTLE
And some of us find that a little terrifying, George. I'll be honest. The Founders made the Constitution hard to change on purpose. Today it got a little less hard. I'm glad for Mr. Bullock. I'm worried about the next person who tries.

DAVID MUIR
And third?

DR. MALCOLM REESE
Third is the cultural one, David. Today the oldest document governing any nation on Earth told an entire generation: you're not too young. You're not waiting your turn. Your turn is now. There are thirty-one-year-old governors and twenty-six-year-old members of Congress who woke up today in a different country. Every eighteen-year-old who voted for the first time in November, and they voted in record numbers, just watched their vote change the Constitution.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
It also changes how the country sees itself. This was the first amendment since the Twenty-Sixth, in 1971, that was about who gets to participate. That one was about eighteen-year-olds voting. This one is about who can lead.

The Political Director pulls up a graphic: a map of the United States. Thirty-eight states in navy. Twelve in gray.

ABC POLITICAL DIRECTOR
Here's the final map. Thirty-eight states ratified. Seven in July alone. The last five in eight days: Kentucky, Missouri, Nebraska, Montana, North Carolina. Four of those five have Republican-controlled legislatures. Seventeen of the thirty-eight ratifying states voted for Donald Trump in 2020. This was a genuinely bipartisan amendment.

DAVID MUIR
And the reaction?

Footage, a series of statements.

DAVID MUIR (V.O.)
President Biden, from the White House, called it, quote, "the people's amendment," and said he'd host a ceremony to witness its certification, just as President Nixon witnessed the certification of the Twenty-Sixth Amendment in 1971. House Speaker Mike Johnson, who never brought the amendment up for debate until the July vote, said in a statement that he respects the states' decision. And in a post on social media, Donald Trump said he'd always thought the kid was tough, and that he expects a very interesting dinner.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
And in Raleigh, at the moment of ratification, the North Carolina House gallery sang "Lift Every Voice and Sing."

MONTAGE — THE INTERNET — DECEMBER 17, 2024

Twitter · #28thAmendment

Trending #1 Worldwide · 11.2M Tweets

Twitter · #38

Trending #2 in United States · 3.4M Tweets

Twitter · #LyricAskedAQuestion

Trending #3 Worldwide · 2.9M Tweets

Twitter · @TheBullpenDaily

IT'S IN THE CONSTITUTION. THE 28TH AMENDMENT. A NINE-YEAR-OLD ASKED A QUESTION ON 4/20/23 AND ON 12/17/24 THE CONSTITUTION OF THE UNITED STATES CHANGED. HE CALLED LYRIC FIRST. SHE ASKED IF THE DOG CAN COME. THE DOG CAN COME.

1.4M Retweets · 9.2M Likes

Twitter · @NAarchives

The 28th Amendment to the U.S. Constitution has been ratified by the requisite number of states. Formal certification by the Archivist of the United States to follow.

401K Retweets · 2.1M Likes

Twitter · @ConstitutionCarl

I opposed this amendment for twenty months. I lost. Fair and square, 38 states, done right. It's in the Constitution now. It's MY Constitution, and it's his. Congratulations, Mr. President-elect. I mean it.

801K Retweets · 6.4M Likes

Twitter · @ConstitutionCarl's replies

@ArizonaGrandpa: "Carl. I'm crying. I'm 74 years old and I'm crying at a man named Constitution Carl. Come to Arizona. I'll buy you a burrito."

1.1M Likes

Twitter · @ConstitutionCarl's replies

@ConstitutionCarl: "@ArizonaGrandpa Deal."

1.6M Likes

Twitter · @RoyChapmanHouston

My sister-in-law's husband in Grand Island, Nebraska voted for it. I'm told I'm responsible. I didn't do anything. I asked her to ask him. Don't make it a whole thing.

1.2M Retweets · 8.8M Likes

TikTok · @nc.pastors.sing

[Video from the North Carolina House gallery: dozens of pastors on their feet, singing "Lift Every Voice and Sing" as the vote board shows 61–59] "the moment the constitution changed. raleigh, nc. 2:14pm."

72.1M views · 18.4M likes

TikTok · @gunner.the.lab

[Fan account, created two hours ago: a photo of a yellow Labrador leaning against Arianna Cummings in the snow] "the most important dog in american constitutional history"

31.4M views · 9.2M likes

Twitter · @SimoneSmilley

My grandmother cast Georgia's electoral votes at noon. My father got North Carolina at 2:14. I'm a Republican who voted for a Democrat and today I watched my whole family change the Constitution. I don't know what to do with my hands.

601K Retweets · 4.7M Likes

Reddit · r/politics

"MEGATHREAD: North Carolina becomes the 38th state to ratify; the 28th Amendment is now part of the U.S. Constitution"

1.8M upvotes · 402,118 comments · Top comment: "The 27th Amendment took 202 years to ratify. The 28th took 169 days. A dog in Montana was involved. I've never loved this country more."

Reddit · r/law

"The 28th Amendment: text, history, and what it means. (Also: yes, Cornelius Smilley's 'Five' list is real; AP confirmed it.)"

211K upvotes

ASSOCIATED PRESS — 2:16 PM EST

North Carolina ratifies 28th Amendment, clearing way for 32-year-old Bullock to be sworn in as president

THE NEW YORK TIMES

THE 28TH AMENDMENT

For the First Time Since 1992, the Constitution Changes, Lowering the Presidential Age to 25 and Ending the Question Over Bullock's Eligibility

THE WASHINGTON POST

38 states, 169 days: How a constitutional amendment for a 32-year-old became law

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL

Ratification Removes Last Big Uncertainty Before Inauguration; Markets Rise

THE NEWS & OBSERVER (RALEIGH)

61–59: North Carolina Puts Amendment Over the Top as Pastors Sing in the Gallery

THE ATLANTA JOURNAL-CONSTITUTION

Odessa Smilley, 96, Casts Georgia's Electoral Votes; Hours Later, Her Son Delivers the 38th State

HELENA INDEPENDENT RECORD

Montana's Vote Came Down to Two Ranchers, a Granddaughter, and a Labrador Named Gunner

POLITICO

Inside Cornelius Smilley's 'Five': the former Biden firewall who delivered the last five states

FOX NEWS

28th Amendment Ratified; Republicans Split Between Celebrating a Democratic Process and Warning of a 'Dangerous Precedent'

VARIETY

The 28th Amendment and the Kid Mayor: Hollywood Reacts to the First Constitutional Change Driven by a Former Child Star

PEOPLE

'Can BET Come to the White House?' Lyric Baker, 10, Gets the First Call

INT. THE WHITE HOUSE — EAST ROOM — DAY

SUPER: FRIDAY, DECEMBER 20, 2024 — 11:00 AM EST

SUPER: THE CERTIFICATION

The largest room in the White House. Crystal chandeliers. Gilbert Stuart's portrait of George Washington on the wall, the one Dolley Madison saved from the British in 1814. Rows of gold chairs. Members of Congress, governors, the legislative leaders of all thirty-eight ratifying states, pastors from North Carolina. A Labrador named Gunner, who is technically not allowed in the East Room and has been personally cleared by the Secret Service at the President's request.

At a small table in front of the presidential seal: the ARCHIVIST OF THE UNITED STATES, with a leather-bound folio. Beside her, as official witnesses, as Nixon witnessed the 26th in 1971: PRESIDENT JOE BIDEN (82), the President-elect, and the Vice President-elect.

And at the end of the table, in a navy dress and a gold tiara her mother told her she absolutely could not wear and she wore anyway: Lyric Baker (10). With BET the dog in a tiny bow tie, held by her father.

The Archivist reads the certification aloud: the text of the amendment, and the list of thirty-eight states in order of ratification. When she reads "North Carolina, December seventeenth, 2024," the pastors in the back rows say "Amen" out loud, and nobody shushes them.

She signs. Then President Biden signs, as witness.

Then the President-elect.

He picks up the pen. Looks down at the document. Hesitates. Then he turns, and holds out the pen to Lyric.

MARC
You first, Lyric-bird.

A murmur through the room. The Archivist glances at President Biden. Biden smiles and nods.

PRESIDENT BIDEN
Ceremonial copy. Go ahead, kiddo.

Lyric takes the pen. On a ceremonial copy of the certification, which will hang in the Smithsonian's National Museum of American History by spring, beneath the signatures of the Archivist of the United States, the forty-sixth President, and the President-elect, a ten-year-old girl writes her name in careful fourth-grade cursive she learned last year in Windsor Hills:

INSERT — THE CEREMONIAL CERTIFICATE: "Lyric Gloria Baker — the girl who asked."

The East Room rises to its feet.

PRESIDENT BIDEN
(leaning to Marc, softly, under the applause)
Nixon didn't do that.

MARC
Nixon didn't have Lyric.

ACT FOUR — "THE CABINET"

INT. HOWARD UNIVERSITY — CRAMTON AUDITORIUM — WASHINGTON, D.C. — DAY

SUPER: SATURDAY, DECEMBER 21, 2024 — 12:00 PM EST

The concert hall at the most famous historically Black university in America, where Thurgood Marshall studied law, where Toni Morrison and Chadwick Boseman studied, where Kamala Harris graduated. Fifteen hundred seats, all filled: Howard students on winter break who stayed in Washington for this, transition staff, press from forty countries.

A simple stage. A podium with the transition seal. Behind it, an empty row of twenty-one chairs.

A banner across the proscenium: "THE BULLOCK-BAKER CABINET — LET'S FIX IT."

INT. CRAMTON AUDITORIUM — BACKSTAGE — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 11:51 AM EST

A cramped green room crowded with twenty-one nervous people in good suits. Not one of them is older than thirty-eight. Marc moves among them shaking hands like a coach before a championship.

Patti Grove (60) pulls him aside.

PATTI
Last chance to make one of them fifty.

MARC
Patti.

PATTI
One. Just one person who remembers the first Gulf War. For the optics.

MARC
You remember the first Gulf War.

PATTI
And I'm not in the Cabinet.

MARC
You're Counselor to the President. You're in every room. That's better.

PATTI
Average age of this Cabinet is going to be about thirty-five. The youngest in American history by a mile. The Senate's going to call it "the Kid Cabinet" by Monday.

MARC
Good. Let them. Every one of these people has done the job they're about to do, at a level most fifty-year-olds haven't. They're not here because they're young. They're here because they're the best. They just happen to be young.

He looks across the room. At a tall woman in a navy suit with her grandmother's pearl studs, standing alone in a corner, staring at her shoes.

MARC
Excuse me. I need to talk to my sister-in-law before she throws up.

He crosses the room to SIMONE SMILLEY (37).

SIMONE
I'm a Republican.

MARC
I know.

SIMONE
I worked for Nikki Haley. I spoke at the RNC. I told you on CNN your border plan was a two out of ten.

MARC
Which is exactly why you're the only person I want running it.

SIMONE
Marc, Homeland Security is the hardest department in the government. Twenty-two agencies. Border Patrol, ICE, the Coast Guard, FEMA, TSA, the Secret Service. And you want to do "one hundred percent legal immigration." With a Republican in charge.

MARC
Your father told me in August: say "orderly." Say "secure." Say "legal" five times in every sentence. He's right. And the person who believes it most in this whole country is you. I can't make immigration legal and orderly with somebody who only believes the legal part. I need somebody who believes the orderly part in their bones.

Simone looks at him for a long time.

SIMONE
My party's going to call me a traitor.

MARC
Your party's going to call you Madam Secretary.

SIMONE
(a shaky laugh)
...Big Mama's going to be insufferable.

MARC
She's already in the front row. She's been there since ten.

INT. CRAMTON AUDITORIUM — STAGE — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 12:04 PM EST

The President-elect at the podium. The Vice President-elect beside him. In the front row: Esther, the twins, Lyric, and, in her wheelchair at the end of the aisle, Odessa. Beside her: Cornelius, Lorraine, Neil.

MARC
Good afternoon, Howard!

A roar from fifteen hundred people.

MARC
Four days ago, the Constitution of the United States changed. Yesterday it was certified. Today, I'm going to introduce you to the people who are going to help me govern.

(beat)
A lot of you have heard what the pundits are already saying. "Too young." "Too

inexperienced." "The Kid Cabinet." Let me save them some time.

(beat)
Every person behind me was born between 1986 and 1995. The oldest is thirty-eight. The youngest is twenty-nine. Average age: about thirty-five.

(beat)
Alexander Hamilton was in his early thirties when he became the first Secretary of the Treasury. Robert F. Kennedy was thirty-five when he became Attorney General. Every generation, somebody says the young people aren't ready. And every generation, the young people build the country anyway.

Applause.

MARC
Some of these names you already know. Elxa Bullock, my big sister, White House Chief of Staff, announced in November. Grace Bullock, my baby sister, White House Press Secretary. And Arianna Cummings, a Harvard Law graduate, a member of the California bar, the woman who won us Montana by befriending a Labrador, my nominee for Attorney General of the United States.

Elxa, Grace, and Arianna step forward to huge applause. In the front row, a yellow Labrador barks once, and Lyric, holding BET, shushes him.

MARC
And now the rest. I'm going to read each name, and each of them is going to come out and take a seat. Let's go.

MONTAGE — THE CABINET — 12:09 PM TO 12:51 PM EST

One by one, each nominee walks onstage to a short introduction from the President-elect and takes a seat in the row of chairs. Each gets a graphic on the giant screen behind the stage: name, title, age, and one line.

GRAPHIC — "SECRETARY OF STATE — DR. NALEDI ASANTE-BROOKS, 36. Born Mar 14, 1988, in Columbus, Ohio, to Ghanaian immigrants. Rhodes Scholar. Former Foreign Service officer; lead U.S. negotiator in

the 2023 Sudan ceasefire talks in Jeddah. Speaks six languages." (D)

MARC
I promised peace talks within a hundred days. Naledi has been sitting across tables from warlords since she was twenty-nine. She's going to make sure we keep that promise.

GRAPHIC — "SECRETARY OF THE TREASURY — JULIAN PARK, 37. Born Sep 2, 1987, in Fort Lee, New Jersey. Former Goldman Sachs partner at 31. Founded an advisory firm that designed sovereign wealth funds for three nations. Architect of the American Sovereign Fund." (Independent)

MARC
Everybody said the Sovereign Fund was a fantasy. Julian has built three of them. He's going to build ours.

GRAPHIC — "SECRETARY OF DEFENSE — CALEB WHITAKER, 38. Born Jun 30, 1986, in Lubbock, Texas. U.S. Army Ranger captain, two tours in Afghanistan; Silver Star. Left active duty 2015 (statutory seven-year requirement met). Harvard Kennedy School. Founded a defense-technology company in Austin." (Republican)

MARC
Caleb's a Republican from Lubbock, Texas. He voted for me anyway. When I asked him why, he said, "Because you didn't ask me to." He's going to be the best Secretary of Defense this country's had in a generation.

GRAPHIC — "SECRETARY OF THE INTERIOR — WINONA REDCLOUD, 33. Born Nov 3, 1991, on the Pine Ridge Reservation, South Dakota. Oglala Lakota. Stanford Law. Environmental and tribal sovereignty attorney." (D)

GRAPHIC — "SECRETARY OF AGRICULTURE — DUSTIN HALE, 35. Born Apr 22, 1989, in Ames, Iowa. Fifth-generation corn and soybean farmer. Iowa State. Founded an ag-tech cooperative serving 9,000 family farms." (Republican)

MARC
Dustin's a fifth-generation Iowa farmer, and a Republican. When I asked him to serve, he said, "Can I still plant in April?" I said yes. He's planting in April.

GRAPHIC — "SECRETARY OF COMMERCE — PRIYA RAMAN, 34. Born Jan 9, 1990, in Edison, New Jersey. Founded a battery manufacturer in Lordstown, Ohio, now employing 4,200 union workers. MIT engineering." (D)

GRAPHIC — "SECRETARY OF LABOR — MARISOL FUENTES, 36. Born Aug 18, 1988, in Detroit, Michigan. UAW local president; led picket lines during the 2023 Stand Up Strike. Wayne State." (D)

MARC
Marisol walked a picket line in 2023 for forty-six days. I walked one for a hundred and eighteen outside my own mother's studio. We bonded.

Natasha, in the third row, laughs and covers her face.

GRAPHIC — "SECRETARY OF HEALTH AND HUMAN SERVICES — DR. JONAH FELD, 37. Born Feb 26, 1987, in Philadelphia. Emergency physician; MD, Penn; MPH, Johns Hopkins. Ran COVID surge operations for New York's public hospital system at 33." (D)

GRAPHIC — "SECRETARY OF HOUSING AND URBAN DEVELOPMENT — DARNELL PRICE, 35. Born Oct 7, 1989, on the South Side of Chicago. Founded a nonprofit developer that built 11,000 affordable homes in a decade." (D)

MARC
Ten million homes. That's the promise. Darnell's already built eleven thousand. Darnell, you've got nine million, nine hundred and eighty-nine thousand to go.

GRAPHIC — "SECRETARY OF TRANSPORTATION — LUCÍA NAVARRO, 31. Born May 30, 1993, in El Paso, Texas. Civil engineer; former chief innovation officer of LA Metro; led the 2028 Olympics transit plan." (D)

GRAPHIC — "SECRETARY OF ENERGY — DR. THEO NAKAMURA, 34. Born Dec 1, 1990, in Honolulu. Plasma physicist at Lawrence Livermore National Laboratory; member of the team that achieved the first fusion ignition, Dec 5, 2022." (D)

MARC
Theo was in the room the first time humanity got more energy out of a fusion reaction than it put in. He was thirty-two. "Make America one hundred percent clean" isn't a slogan when you hire the guy who did that.

GRAPHIC — "SECRETARY OF EDUCATION — KEISHA MONROE-ELLIS, 33. Born Jul 15, 1991, in Jackson, Mississippi. Former 4th-grade teacher; youngest school superintendent in Mississippi history; led her district from an F rating to an A in four years." (D)

MARC
Keisha taught fourth grade. Like Mrs. Gloria Baker. When I told Mrs. Baker, she said, "Finally, somebody who knows what a fourth-grader is."

Gloria Baker, in the second row, stands up and points at Keisha. Keisha points back. The crowd roars.

GRAPHIC — "SECRETARY OF VETERANS AFFAIRS — ANDRE 'DRE' COLEMAN, 36. Born Mar 3, 1988, in Norfolk, Virginia. U.S. Marine Corps sergeant; lost both legs to an IED in Helmand Province, 2011. Two-time Paralympic medalist. Veterans advocate." (Republican)

Dre walks onstage on his prosthetics. The entire auditorium stands. He waves them down and sits.

MARC
Dre's a Republican. He's a Marine. And when I asked him to serve, he said, "Sir, I'll take the job if you promise me one thing: no veteran ever waits for care again." I promised. He took the job.

A long, emotional applause. Marc lets it go on.

Then he turns to the last empty chair.

MARC
The last Cabinet department. The hardest one. Twenty-two agencies. The border. Immigration. FEMA. TSA. The Coast Guard. And, yes, the Secret Service, which means the person I'm about to name will be in charge of the people who protect my daughters.

(beat)
I promised one hundred percent legal immigration. Orderly. Secure. Legal. I need somebody who believes in every one of those words. Not just the ones I like best.

(beat)
She's a Republican. She worked for Nikki Haley. She spoke at the Republican

National Convention in Milwaukee. On national television, she gave my border plan a two out of ten.

A ripple of disbelief through the auditorium. In the front row, Odessa sits up very straight. Cornelius's mouth falls open.

MARC
And then, on national television, she said she was voting for character.

(beat)
Ladies and gentlemen, my nominee for Secretary of Homeland Security: my sister-in-law, Simone Smilley.

Simone walks out onstage.

The sound in Cramton Auditorium is something between a gasp and a roar. Reporters are on their phones before she reaches her chair. In the front row, Lorraine has both hands over her mouth. Neil is on his feet, applauding. Esther is crying.

And Odessa Smilley, ninety-six years old, reaches up, grabs the arm of her son, and pulls herself to her feet out of her wheelchair. She stands, unassisted, for the first time in a month, and claps for her granddaughter.

GRAPHIC — "SECRETARY OF HOMELAND SECURITY — SIMONE SMILLEY, 37. Born Jul 7, 1987, in Atlanta, Georgia. Republican strategist; senior adviser, Haley for President 2023–24; former senior policy staffer, House Homeland Security Committee." (Republican)

Simone takes her seat at the end of the row. She looks out at her grandmother standing in the front row, and she completely loses it.

INT. CRAMTON AUDITORIUM — STAGE — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 12:53 PM EST

MARC
Six more Cabinet-level positions. Quickly, because Grace is giving me the signal, and she's terrifying.

A rapid succession of graphics on the screen as each nominee joins the row:

GRAPHIC — "U.N. AMBASSADOR — RAFAEL ORTIZ-RIVERA, 32. Born Sep 24, 1992, in San Juan, Puerto Rico. Former State Department official; coordinated Hurricane Maria and Fiona recovery diplomacy." (D)

GRAPHIC — "DIRECTOR, OFFICE OF MANAGEMENT AND BUDGET — HANNAH LIU, 30. Born Jun 11, 1994, in San Francisco. Former Federal Reserve senior economist; youngest OMB Director in history." (D)

GRAPHIC — "EPA ADMINISTRATOR — KAI MAHOE, 29. Born Feb 8, 1995, in Lahaina, Hawai'i. Climate scientist; lost her childhood home in the 2023 Lahaina fire." (D)

GRAPHIC — "U.S. TRADE REPRESENTATIVE — OMAR HADDAD, 35. Born Nov 19, 1989, in Dearborn, Michigan. Trade attorney; former counsel on the USMCA negotiations. Lead negotiator for North American partnership talks." (D)

MARC
Dearborn loaned me their trust in February. Omar Haddad is from Dearborn. He's going to lead our negotiations with Canada and Mexico. I'm paying it back with interest.

GRAPHIC — "DIRECTOR OF NATIONAL INTELLIGENCE — EVELYN CHO, 38. Born Apr 5, 1986, in Fairfax, Virginia. Twelve years as a CIA operations officer; Korean and Mandarin speaker; former deputy director of the National Counterterrorism Center." (Nonpartisan)

Then a final graphic: "WHITE HOUSE SENIOR STAFF."

MARC
And at the White House. Patti Grove, Counselor to the President. She's sixty. She's not in the Cabinet. She's in charge of everyone who is.

(laughter, a roar for Patti, who waves once and looks at the floor)
National Security Advisor: Mara Lindgren, thirty-seven, former deputy national security advisor for Europe. White House Counsel: Benjamin Osei, thirty-four, former Supreme Court clerk. Communications Director: my best friend since a Donohue Channel set in 2003, Tayia Boyd.

Tayia, in the third row, screams. She did not know. Grace, beside her, did.

MARC
Director of the Office of Public Engagement and Senior Advisor for Bipartisan Affairs: the only member of Republicans for Bullock who was there on day one, when it had one member. Tyler Chapman.

Tyler, in the third row, freezes. Two seats down, Roy Chapman, flown in from Houston, slowly removes his reading glasses and stares at his son.

ROY
(to Mae, stunned)
He just made our boy a White House official, Mae.

MAE
Don't make it a whole thing, Roy.

ROY
Mae, it IS a whole thing.

MARC
And Deputy Chief of Staff for Operations: the man who's protected my family since 2015, eleven years a Secret Service agent before that. Dante Reyes.

Dante, standing by the stage door with his arms crossed, keeps a perfectly professional face. His jaw, very slightly, quivers.

Marc turns to the full row: twenty-one nominees and senior staff. The oldest is thirty-eight. Then he turns back to the audience.

MARC
This is the youngest Cabinet in American history. Four Republicans. One Independent. One nonpartisan. Fifteen Democrats. They come from Ohio, New Jersey, Texas, South Dakota, Iowa, Michigan, Pennsylvania, Illinois, Hawai'i, Mississippi, Virginia, Georgia, Puerto Rico, California, and Pine Ridge.

(beat)
The Senate gets to decide. That's how it works. I'm asking them to hold every one of these people to the hardest standard there is. And then I'm asking them to confirm the best young team this country

has ever assembled.

(beat)
They say we're too young.

Fifteen hundred Howard students, on their feet, before he can finish:

AUDIENCE
BET!

INT. CRAMTON AUDITORIUM — BACKSTAGE — LATER

SUPER: 1:32 PM EST

The green room, emptying. Marc finds Cornelius in the hallway, alone, staring at a framed photograph on the wall: Howard's 1961 student body, a sea of young Black faces in front of Founders Library.

MARC
Dad. I have one more job.

CORNELIUS
I'm sixty-six. You just told fifteen hundred people your oldest Cabinet member is thirty-eight.

MARC
It's not a Cabinet job. Senior Advisor to the President. For the South. For faith. For the churches. For whatever you want. Office in the West Wing. You can walk to the Oval in eleven seconds. I timed it.

Cornelius looks at him for a long time. Then back at the photograph.

CORNELIUS
I was in a picture like that once. Morehouse, 1980. We were going to change the world.

MARC
You did.

CORNELIUS
I helped. A little. And I wasted a great deal of it being angry.

(beat)
No, son.

MARC
Dad —

CORNELIUS
My mother is ninety-six years old. She stood up out of that wheelchair today for my daughter. I don't know how many more times she's going to stand up. I spent fifty years in Washington chasing something I was never going to get. I'm going to spend whatever time she has left at her table in Atlanta.

(beat)
You have a phone. I'll answer it. Every time. I'll even stay on the line.

Marc looks at him. Nods slowly.

MARC
That's better than an office.

CORNELIUS
It is.

(beat)
And you put my daughter in charge of the Secret Service.

MARC
I did.

CORNELIUS
A Republican.

MARC
Your daughter.

Cornelius looks at him for a very long moment.

CORNELIUS
Thank you, son.

ACT FIVE — "THE KID CABINET"

MONTAGE — REACTIONS — DECEMBER 21–23, 2024

— SATURDAY, 2:15 PM EST. A senior Republican senator on cable news, speaking for many: the Senate will give the nominees "fair hearings and tough questions," but calls the Cabinet "a JV squad for the most dangerous job on Earth." Then, asked about Simone Smilley, Caleb Whitaker, Dustin Hale, and Dre Coleman, he pauses: "Those four, I'd vote for tomorrow."

— SATURDAY, 3:40 PM EST. Senate Majority Leader Chuck Schumer (74) says Democrats will move "quickly and thoroughly," with hearings starting the week of January sixth, after the new Senate is sworn in.

— SUNDAY, DECEMBER 22. On "This Week," George Stephanopoulos notes that, if confirmed, every one of the nominees would be the youngest person ever to lead their department.

— MONDAY, DECEMBER 23. Fox News: "BULLOCK'S 'KID CABINET': WHO ARE THESE PEOPLE?" A segment that starts as a mockery and ends, after a long clip of Dre Coleman walking onstage on his prosthetics, with the host admitting, "I'm going to be honest, I don't know how you vote against that guy."

Twitter · #KidCabinet

Trending #1 Worldwide · 7.8M Tweets

Twitter · #MadamSecretarySmilley

Trending #2 in United States · 3.1M Tweets

Twitter · @TheBullpenDaily

AVERAGE AGE 35. FOUR REPUBLICANS. SIMONE SMILLEY AT HOMELAND SECURITY. ODESSA STOOD UP OUT OF HER WHEELCHAIR. TYLER IS A WHITE HOUSE OFFICIAL AND ROY SAID "IT IS A WHOLE THING." I'VE RUN OUT OF CAPS LOCK.

1.1M Retweets · 7.9M Likes

Twitter · @SimoneSmilley

Last year I gave my brother-in-law's border plan a 2/10 on national television. Today he asked me to run it. Orderly. Secure. Legal. I'll be the one saying all three words.

701K Retweets · 5.8M Likes

Twitter · @GOPHomelandHawk

A Republican running Bullock's open-borders DHS. Either she's going to be a traitor to her party or a traitor to his platform. Can't be both.

41K Retweets · 211K Likes

Twitter · @GOPHomelandHawk's replies

@SimoneSmilley: "Watch me."

901K Likes

Twitter · @RoyChapmanHouston

My son is a White House official. I've been told I'm "allowed to make it a whole thing." So: my son is a White House official. That's the whole thing.

2.4M Retweets · 16.1M Likes

Twitter · @TayiaBoyd

I'm the White House Communications Director. He didn't tell me. Grace knew. Grace has known for TWO WEEKS. I'm never forgiving either of them. (I'm forgiving them by Tuesday.)

801K Retweets · 6.2M Likes

Twitter · @GraceBullock

@TayiaBoyd I'm the Press Secretary, Tayia. Keeping secrets is literally my job now. Also I still pay $8.

611K Retweets · 5.1M Likes

TikTok · @dre.coleman.usmc

[Video: Dre Coleman walking onstage at Howard on his prosthetics as 1,500 people rise to their feet] "secretary of veterans affairs-designate. I lost my legs at 23. I'm 36. I'm not done."

88.2M views · 24.1M likes

TikTok · @howard.bison.2026

[Video from the audience: the whole Cabinet in a row, all born 1986–1995] "the cabinet is literally our older siblings"

41.4M views · 11.8M likes

Reddit · r/politics

"Bullock names full Cabinet: average age ~35, four Republicans, Simone Smilley at DHS, Caleb Whitaker at Defense, Julian Park at Treasury"

1.1M upvotes · 211,882 comments · Top comment: "Alexander Hamilton was in his early 30s at Treasury. RFK was 35 at Justice. Every generation thinks the next one isn't ready. Every generation is wrong."

Reddit · r/neoliberal

"Julian Park at Treasury is the most interesting Treasury pick in 50 years and nobody is talking about it because Simone Smilley at DHS broke the internet"

88K upvotes

ASSOCIATED PRESS

Bullock unveils youngest Cabinet in U.S. history, average age about 35; names four Republicans, including sister-in-law Simone Smilley at Homeland Security

THE NEW YORK TIMES

A Cabinet Born in the '80s and '90s: Bullock Bets on Youth, and on Republicans

THE WASHINGTON POST

The 'Kid Cabinet': Who Bullock's 21 nominees are and what they've done

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL

Julian Park, Sovereign-Fund Architect, Tapped for Treasury; Markets Cautiously Welcome Pick

POLITICO

Senate Republicans privately say 4 GOP nominees could pass easily; the fight will be over State, Treasury and HHS

AXIOS

Bullock's Cabinet by the numbers: 21 nominees, ages 29–38, 4 Republicans, 1 Paralympian, 1 fusion physicist

FOX NEWS

Bullock's 'Kid Cabinet' Draws Scrutiny, but GOP Senators Praise Republican Picks Whitaker, Hale, Coleman, Smilley

THE ATLANTA JOURNAL-CONSTITUTION

From Haley Adviser to Homeland Security: Atlanta's Simone Smilley Tapped by Brother-in-Law

HOUSTON CHRONICLE

Houston's Tyler Chapman Named to White House Senior Staff; Father Roy: 'It Is a Whole Thing'

THE DETROIT NEWS

Detroit's Marisol Fuentes, UAW Strike Leader, Tapped for Labor Secretary

VARIETY

Tayia Boyd, 'Marc My Words' Co-Star, Named White House Communications Director

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER

Two Former Donohue Channel Stars Now Run White House Communications

PEOPLE

Odessa Smilley, 96, Rises From Her Wheelchair as Granddaughter Is Named to the Cabinet

TAG

INT. SMILLEY HOUSE — PARLOR — CASCADE HEIGHTS, ATLANTA — NIGHT

SUPER: TUESDAY, DECEMBER 24, 2024 — CHRISTMAS EVE — 11:14 PM EST

A Christmas tree in the corner of the parlor, decorated with ornaments going back to 1952: a paper star Thaddeus made in kindergarten, a glass angel from Josiah's mother. Presents piled underneath. Josiah's portrait over the mantel, wreathed in holly.

The house is asleep. The twins and Lyric in sleeping bags upstairs in Esther's childhood bedroom. Esther asleep. Odessa asleep. Everyone asleep except two men.

Marc (32) on the floral sofa, the same sofa Odessa has had since 1966, in pajamas and a Christmas sweater Victoria bought him that says "PRESIDENT-ELF." Across from him, in his father's old wingback chair, a glass of eggnog untouched on the side table: Cornelius (66).

CORNELIUS
You asked me in Philadelphia. In the hotel. I said after the election, when we have time.

MARC
You don't have to, Dad.

CORNELIUS
I know I don't.

A long silence. The tree lights blink.

CORNELIUS
August seventeenth, 1974. A Saturday. Thad was twenty-seven. He'd been working for my father's voter league for three years. He was going to run for the state House in '76. Everybody knew he'd win. Everybody knew he'd go to Congress after that.

(beat)
That week, Joan and Victor were on the cover of Jet. A wedding-anniversary story. Four years married. "Hollywood's Golden Couple." The whole city saw it. My father hid the magazine. My mother found it.

MARC
And Thad saw it.

CORNELIUS
Thad saw it. He'd driven down to Macon for a voter-registration meeting at a church. Drove back late. I was sixteen. I was awake, in this room, watching a movie on that same television set, and the telephone rang at a quarter to one in the morning. It was Thad. From a pay phone at a Gulf station on I-75 outside Forsyth.

Cornelius stops. Looks at the paper star on the tree.

CORNELIUS
I've told everybody for fifty years that he called me drunk and heartbroken and that the Donohues killed him.

(beat)
That isn't what happened.

Marc sits up very slowly.

CORNELIUS
He called me because he'd seen the magazine at the Gulf station, on the rack by the register. And he said, "Corny, I saw her picture. She looks happy. I'm happy for her." He said, "I'm over it, little brother. I'm finally over it. I'm going to meet somebody in Macon next month, a teacher, and I'm going to run for the House, and I'm going to be okay." He was laughing. He wasn't drunk. He'd been up since five in the morning registering voters. He was tired.

(beat)
He said, "Tell Mama I'll be home in an hour. Leave the porch light on."

Cornelius's voice breaks.

CORNELIUS
He fell asleep at the wheel twenty minutes later. Just south of Barnesville. The state trooper said there were no skid marks. He never woke up.

(beat)
And I was sixteen years old and I couldn't stand that it was nobody's fault. That my

brother, who was going to be a Congressman and a Senator and maybe more, died because he was tired after registering voters all day. So I decided it was Joan's fault. And Victor's. And the Donohues'. I told my parents he sounded upset. I told the reporters. I told myself. And after a while I couldn't remember the truth anymore. I only remembered the version where somebody took him from us.

Silence. The clock on the mantel.

CORNELIUS
He forgave her, Marc. Before he died. He'd already forgiven her. He was happy for her.

(beat)
I'm the only one who never did. For fifty years I carried a grudge my brother had already put down.

Marc doesn't say anything. He gets up. Crosses the room. Kneels down in front of his father-in-law's chair, the way he knelt before Odessa's wheelchair on the Rocky steps.

MARC
Does Mama Odessa know?

CORNELIUS
I told her tonight. After the girls went to bed. In the kitchen. Fifty years late.

MARC
What did she say?

CORNELIUS
She said, "I know, baby. I always knew. I was waiting for you to know."

Cornelius puts his face in his hands. Marc puts his arms around him. Two men in a dark parlor on Christmas Eve, under the portrait of a preacher, beside a paper star a little boy made in 1952.

After a long time, Cornelius lifts his head. Wipes his eyes. Looks at the floral sofa across the room.

CORNELIUS
That's the couch.

MARC
What?

CORNELIUS
That's Thad's couch. My mother's had it since 1966. Every Christmas Eve, after midnight, he'd climb up on it and give a speech. "My fellow Americans." My father would yell from upstairs, "Thaddeus, get off your mother's couch." And Thad would say...

MARC
"When I'm President, I'll stand wherever I want."

Cornelius looks at the clock on the mantel. 11:59 PM.

He looks at Marc.

CORNELIUS
It's almost midnight, Mr. President-elect.

Marc looks at him. Then at the couch.

He takes off his slippers. Climbs up onto Odessa Smilley's floral sofa, the one from 1966, in his PRESIDENT-ELF sweater. Stands up straight. The clock begins to chime midnight.

MARC
(softly, so as not to wake the house)
My fellow Americans.

From upstairs, through the old ceiling, a thin, sleepy, ninety-six-year-old voice:

ODESSA (O.S.)
Marc-Anthony, get off my couch.

Marc freezes. Cornelius starts to laugh, then cry, then laugh, all at once.

Marc grins. Raises his chin. And says it, for Thaddeus Smilley, on Christmas, on his couch, fifty years late:

MARC
Mama Odessa. When I'm President...

(beat)
...I'll stand wherever I want.

A long silence from upstairs.

Then, very faintly, through the ceiling, the sound of a ninety-six-year-old woman laughing in the dark.

The clock finishes chiming. It's Christmas Day.

On the mantel, the twins' card, which Cornelius brought downstairs from his study tonight and placed beside Josiah's portrait, propped against the frame: "We are just your granddaughters. Footnote: This is true."

SMASH TO BLACK.

SUPER: INAUGURATION DAY: MONDAY, JANUARY 20, 2025 — 27 DAYS

SUPER: END OF CHAPTER ELEVEN

CONTINUITY LEDGER — CHAPTER 11

Timeline: Fri Nov 8, 2024, 1:47 PM PST → Wed Dec 25, 2024, 12:00 AM EST. **RATIFICATION: Tue Dec 17, 2024, 2:14 PM EST, North Carolina House 61–59 (NC Senate 30–20 that morning), the 38th state. Certified Fri Dec 20, 2024, 11:00 AM EST, White House East Room** (Archivist signs; Biden witnesses, following Nixon's 1971 precedent for the 26th Amendment). The 28th Amendment lowers the presidential/VP age minimum from 35 to 25; it is the first amendment since the 27th (May 7, 1992, four months after Marc's birth). Passage to ratification: 169 days (Jul 1 → Dec 17).

The last five ("The Five"): #34 Kentucky, Tue Dec 10 (Senate 25–13, House 64–35; Rev. Ellison: "1998 paid in full"). #35 Missouri, Thu Dec 12 (Mother Doris Walker, 81, St. Louis AME, the Speaker's mother-in-law; **Lorraine's 63rd birthday**). #36 Nebraska, Fri Dec 13 (33–16 in the unicameral; via Roy Chapman's sister-in-law's husband, a state senator from Grand Island). #37 Montana, Mon Dec 16 (Senate 26–24, House 51–49; Hank Dorsey, 61, legislative counsel; **Gunner the Labrador befriends Arianna once he learns she's from Chicago**; two Hi-Line ranchers flip). #38 North Carolina, Tue Dec 17 (Rev. Harold Bryant, 68, of Raleigh; Reps. Hollis of Halifax and Tate of Edgecombe, both Republicans, vote yes; the gallery sings "Lift Every Voice and Sing"). 17 of the 38 ratifying states voted Trump in 2020.

Electoral College, Tue Dec 17: 359 Bullock-Baker, 179 Trump-Vance. **Odessa Smilley, 96, is a Georgia presidential elector** (signed at the Georgia State Capitol at noon). Congress counts the votes Mon Jan 6, 2025.

Ages (Dec 2024): Marc 32 · Esther 32 · Amond 32 · Harmony 32 · Emma & Victoria 12 · Lyric 10 · Arianna 32 · Elxa 34 · Grace 30 · Tayia 32 · Tyler 32 · Tyrese 33 · Natasha 53 · Robert 55 · Victor 78 · Joan 76 · Odessa 96 · Cornelius 66 · **Lorraine 63 (Dec 12)** · Neil 40 · Simone 37 · Bea 69 · Patti 60 · Dante 43 · Roy 67 · Mae 65 · Gloria 58 · Agent Ruth Okonjo 48. Real people: Biden 82 (Nov 20) · Trump 78 · Muir 51 (Nov 8) · Stephanopoulos 63 · Schumer 74 (Nov 23).

THE CABINET (announced Sat Dec 21, 2024, Howard University, Cramton Auditorium); all born 1986–1995, average age ~35 for the 15 departments: State: **Dr. Naledi Asante-Brooks**, 36 (b. Mar 14, 1988, Columbus, OH; D) · Treasury: **Julian Park**, 37 (b. Sep 2, 1987, Fort Lee, NJ; Independent; Sovereign Fund architect) · Defense: **Caleb Whitaker**, 38 (b. Jun 30, 1986, Lubbock, TX; R; Ranger, Silver Star; left active duty 2015) · Attorney General: **Arianna Cummings**, 32 (b. Oct 25, 1992; D; grew up on Chicago's South Side) · Interior: **Winona Redcloud**, 33 (b. Nov 3, 1991, Pine Ridge; Oglala Lakota; D) · Agriculture: **Dustin Hale**, 35 (b. Apr 22, 1989, Ames, IA; R) ·

Commerce: **Priya Raman**, 34 (b. Jan 9, 1990, Edison, NJ; D) · Labor: **Marisol Fuentes**, 36 (b. Aug 18, 1988, Detroit; UAW; D) · HHS: **Dr. Jonah Feld**, 37 (b. Feb 26, 1987, Philadelphia; D) · HUD: **Darnell Price**, 35 (b. Oct 7, 1989, Chicago; D) · Transportation: **Lucía Navarro**, 31 (b. May 30, 1993, El Paso; D) · Energy: **Dr. Theo Nakamura**, 34 (b. Dec 1, 1990, Honolulu; fusion ignition team; D) · Education: **Keisha Monroe-Ellis**, 33 (b. Jul 15, 1991, Jackson, MS; D) · Veterans Affairs: **Andre "Dre" Coleman**, 36 (b. Mar 3, 1988, Norfolk, VA; USMC, double amputee, Paralympian; R) · Homeland Security: **Simone Smilley**, 37 (b. Jul 7, 1987, Atlanta; R). **Cabinet-level:** Chief of Staff **Elxa Bullock**, 34 (named Nov 11) · UN Ambassador **Rafael Ortiz-Rivera**, 32 (b. Sep 24, 1992, San Juan; D) · OMB **Hannah Liu**, 30 (b. Jun 11, 1994; D) · EPA **Kai Mahoe**, 29 (b. Feb 8, 1995, Lahaina; D) · USTR **Omar Haddad**, 35 (b. Nov 19, 1989, Dearborn; D; leads North American partnership talks) · DNI **Evelyn Cho**, 38 (b. Apr 5, 1986; nonpartisan). **White House senior staff:** Press Secretary **Grace Bullock**, 30 (named Nov 15) · Counselor to the President **Patti Grove**, 60 · National Security Advisor **Mara Lindgren**, 37 (b. Oct 2, 1987) · White House Counsel **Benjamin Osei**, 34 (b. Mar 17, 1990) · Communications Director **Tayia Boyd**, 32 (a surprise) · Director of Public Engagement / Senior Advisor for Bipartisan Affairs **Tyler Chapman**, 32 · Deputy Chief of Staff for Operations **Dante Reyes**, 43. **Cornelius declines the Senior Advisor role** to stay with Odessa in Atlanta ("I'll answer every time. I'll even stay on the line."). Senate hearings begin the week of Jan 6, 2025.

Other events: Trump concedes by phone, Fri Nov 8, 4:47 PM EST, and accepts the dinner invitation ("You're a tough kid. Don't let them change you."). AZ and NV called Nov 9 (final 359–179). Biden–Bullock Oval meeting, Wed Nov 13. Arianna named AG Nov 20 (the youngest since RFK at 35). FL Senate recount: Mucarsel-Powell wins by 2,814 (Nov 22), **Senate 52–48**. **House final 238–197** (Nov 26). **Thanksgiving at Smilley House (Nov 28): the Smilleys and Donohues together for the first time in 55 years; Joan seated at Odessa's left; Marc at the kids' (folding) table.** Marc calls Lyric first after ratification; she asks if BET can come to the White House (yes). At certification, Lyric signs a ceremonial copy: "Lyric Gloria Baker — the girl who asked" (headed to the Smithsonian NMAH). Biden: "Nixon didn't do that." Marc: "Nixon didn't have Lyric." Gunner attends the East Room ceremony. Odessa stands up from her wheelchair for Simone. **The Thaddeus truth (Christmas Eve):** Aug 17, 1974, a Saturday; Thad (27) called Cornelius (16) at 12:45 AM from a Gulf station pay phone outside Forsyth on I-75 after seeing Joan and Victor on the cover of Jet; he was happy for her and "finally over it," planning to run for the state House in '76 and meet a teacher from Macon; he fell asleep at the wheel south of Barnesville, with no skid marks. Cornelius invented the

"heartbroken" version and blamed the Donohues. Odessa: "I always knew. I was waiting for you to know." Marc stands on Thad's couch (Odessa's since 1966) at midnight Christmas Eve. Odessa (O.S.): "Marc-Anthony, get off my couch." Marc's sweater: "PRESIDENT-ELF."

Looming event (in-world): INAUGURATION DAY, Mon Jan 20, 2025 (27 days). Congress counts the electoral votes Mon Jan 6, 2025. Cabinet confirmation hearings.